b. Do you see sparrows around your house now-a-days. Have you ever thought where they are or where they have gone? Read the following text and learn more about sparrows.

Homeless House Sparrows

1. In recent times the house sparrow (Passer domesticus indicus) has become one of the endangered birds. The reasons for its decline in number are many such as lack of nesting places, lack of food etc. We are hard pressed to spot the humble house sparrow, known as, "angadikuruvi" and we need something like World Sparrow Day observed on March 20th every year since 2010, to remind us of our close connection and this bird, that has over centuries successfully adapted itself to human life.



2. Once upon a time, nests of house sparrows were to be found in almost every household as well as in public places such as markets (hence the name "angadikuruvi"), bus bays and railway stations where they lived in colonies and survived on food grains, insects and worms. Nowadays they are facing a crisis of survival in what was once their natural range/habitat.They can only be seen in television and pictures.

a. Why is a sparrow called "angadikuruvi"?

b. What sort of crisis are sparrows facing today?

3. Sparrows are small, plump, brown-grey birds with short tails and stubby powerful beaks. They are small birds with a distinct difference between male and female birds; the male has a black throat, white cheeks and black bib while the female is brown with an eye stripe. Their average size is 14–16cms and weigh nearly 26–32 gms.One peculiar behaviour of house sparrows is dust bathing. The sparrows will first scratch a hole in the ground with their feet, then lie in it and fling dirt or sand over their bodies with flicks of their wings. They will also bathe in water. Water bathing is similar to dust bathing, with the sparrow standing in shallow water and splashing water over its back with its wings, and also ducking its head under water.



c. How do sparrows take a dust bath?

4. House sparrow is listed in Red Data Book of International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN). The reasons for the decline of the house sparrows are many. Studies show that it may be because of the destruction of its habitat, due to urbanization and super market culture taking over local markets, lack of insects that are vital for the young chicks and even electromagnetic pollution from mobile phone towers that harm its reproductive cycle. In addition, use of broad spectrum insecticides has destroyed insects and thus the availability of insects to feed on. It also leads to inaccessibility of pesticide free fruits. Recent surveys reveal sparrows near organic farms looking for food on the ground.

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